Ben **Jaques-Leslie**

Program Evaluator and Data Scientist

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Education

Management Concepts — *Virtual*

Agile Project Management for the Federal Environment — *2025*

Management Concepts — *Virtual*

Project Management Principles — *2024*

Coleridge Initiative — *New York, New York, USA*

Applied Data Analysis Training Program — *2020*

School of Global Policy & Strategy, University of California, San Diego — *La Jolla, California, USA*

Master of Pacific/International Affairs — *2010*

- Career focus: Development and Non-Profit Management
- Regional focus: China
- Honor: Most Valuable Teaching Assistant
- Development Club Treasurer
- Net Impact Chapter Director of Club Development

Beijing Normal University — *Beijing, China*

Summer Chinese Language Intensive — *2009*

University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill — *Chapel Hill, North Carolina, USA*

Bachelor of Science, Mathematics — *2002*

- Major: Pure Math
- Minor: History
- Honors: Dean's List and Pi Mu Epsilon Math Honors Fraternity

Shandong University — *Jinan, China*

Santa Barbara City College Pacific Rim Studies Program — *2001*

Research and data experience

Apricity Consulting — *Denver, CO, USA*

Consultant — *2025 - current*

- Reviewed evaluation frameworks and data collection instruments for international development projects across Latin America, South Asia, the Middle East, and Africa, providing technical feedback on methodology and measurement approaches
- Verified program results by analyzing monitoring and evaluation data from implementing agencies, conducting data quality assessments, and cross-referencing reported outcomes against established performance indicators
- Processed and analyzed survey data using R to assess program effectiveness, including Spanish-language survey data from water quality interventions and generating statistical summaries to inform program design and stakeholder reporting

Minnesota Management and Budget — *Saint Paul, Minnesota, USA*

Results Management Coordinator — *2025 - current*

- Provide grant evaluation consultation to Health and Human Services agencies under Minnesota Statute 16A.055, designing performance measurement plans with quantifiable objectives using the Results-Based Accountability framework
- Leverage R programming and large language models (LLMs) to enhance data analysis, automate reporting processes, and support various Results team initiatives for evidence-based decision making
- Deliver technical assistance and training to agency staff on performance measurement, data collection planning, and outcome measurement through collaborative partnership model across Minnesota state government to help improve their legislative proposals

Scale Link — *USA*

Data Science Consultant — *2025 - current*

- Developed predictive models for CDFI microloan portfolio outcomes using random forest algorithms, incorporating rules-based classification, unsupervised clustering methodologies, and loan performance metrics to assess risk
- Conducted extensive exploratory data analysis of microloan portfolios and integrated large language models into R workflows to generate automated narrative descriptions of cluster characteristics and loan performance patterns

United States Office of Personnel Management *Washington, DC, USA*

Program Evaluator *2023 - 2025*

- Conducted causal analysis using designed statistical matching to evaluate the effect of remote status on interest and hiring of applicants to Federal jobs, presented the work internally and externally, and publishing the report on the agency website
- Developed an study design and began data cleaning of a study on the state of remote and telework across Federal governemnt
- Collaboratively wrote an project proposal and study design to evaluate the effects of pay changes at the Transportation Security Administration (TSA) on attrition of staff
- Co-authored a literature review examining how government social media engagement impacts public trust in government institutions
- Presented to and collaborated with federal evaluation leaders through the Evaluation Officers Council and Interagency Council on Evaluation Policy, contributing to government-wide evaluation practices and knowledge sharing
- Drove agency's strategic evaluation planning through development of performance measurement workshops, comprehensive research inventory, adaptation of relevant cross-agency learning priorities, and design of evaluation capacity assessment tools
- Leading evaluation team's transition to advanced data analysis tools (R, GitHub, Azure DevOps); establishing team infrastructure, developing standard operating procedures, and providing technical training for adoption
- Worked with external researchers from other agencies and universities to establish the foundation for new studies using various mechanisms
- Successfully procured and implemented a hybrid technical training program introducing R for data science to the team and other data experts within the agency
- Developed an internal team training plan by surveying team members to assess their expertise and interests, incorporating initiatives such as lunch-and-learn sessions and investing in external training opportunities for the team

United States General Services Administration *Washington, DC, USA*

Data Scientist *2022 - 2023*

- Conducting descriptive and cluster analysis on working patters of agency staff
- Detailed to the Office of Personnel Management the evaluate the effect of remote work job positings on candidate interest, diversity, and quality
- Developing tools to support high-quality research, including standardized data project processes and testing the use of fabricated data

Minnesota Department of Human Services *Saint Paul, Minnesota, USA*

Research Scientist *2021 - 2023*

- Transitioning regular reports from PDFs to interactive dashboards in Tableau
- Developing performance measure of the Minnesota Family Investment Program for the Governor's One Minnesota goals
- Continued much of the work assigned as a Agency Policy Specialist, listed below

Minnesota Department of Human Services *Saint Paul, Minnesota, USA*

Agency Policy Specialist *2016 - 2021*

- Produce the Self-Support Index, the statewide performance measure for the Minnesota Family Investment Program (MFIP), using R and SQL to extract state administrative data, merging with other data sources, and developing a predictive model of county performance
- Develop reports using data from Minnesota's public assistance programs' for internal and external stakeholders used for developing legislation, responding to federal inquiries, making operations and policy decisions, and answering research questions
- Collaborating with external research partners, including the Minneapolis Federal Reserve, the University of Minnesota, Indiana University, and ideas42 to use agency data
- Member of the Minnesota 2-Generation Policy Network, acting as evaluation contact for White Earth Nation, providing technical assistance to use data from WECARE, the public assistance assessment tool developed by the tribe
- Training state and local officials on the Self-Support Index, reaching over 300 staff people
- Member of the Early Childhood Longitudinal Data System (ECLDS), which makes aggregate data on children birth to third grade from across state agencies, in particular working on the Data and Research Committee, the Family Ecology project, and MN Kids Explorer
- Extracted, cleaned, and analyzed daily application and participant data into documents, presentations, and spreadsheets for division, department, and state leadership, including weekly food security presentations to the governor
- Created data infastructure to implement Emergency SNAP, calculating the appropriate increases to food grants, adjusting for unique and changing policies, providing more than $20,000,000 in food support to all eligible Minnesota familiies monthly
- Provided data support to Pandemic EBT, providing food support to children receiving free and reduced price lunch, fuzzy matching application data to administrative data, constructing application information for help line staff and for outreach to applicants, sending more than $70,000,000 in food support to students in Minnesota
- Project coordinator for Minnesota's participation in the TANF Data Collaborative, a effort to increase data analysis capacity and use in state governments

Abdul Latif Jameel Poverty Action Lab (J-PAL), MIT *Cambridge, Massachusetts, USA*

Senior Research and Training Manager *2014 - 2016*

- Lead restructuring of J-PAL staff development, including major changes to the style and content of in-person staff training, and developing new systems for personalized staff development
- Writing, launching, and analyzing biannual surveys of J-PAL staff
- Tracking and developing plans to improve engagement with J-PAL's affiliate network, including running biannual surveys
- Coordinating other J-PAL Sector Program Managers at J-PAL to improve systems and consistency in initiative management, sector outreach, matchmaking with researchers and implementers, and internal training, including development and management of the Initiative Coordinator
- Continued much of the work assigned as a Research manager, listed below

Abdul Latif Jameel Poverty Action Lab (J-PAL), MIT *Cambridge, Massachusetts, USA*

Agriculture Sector Program Manager *2011 - 2016*

- Managing the Abdul Latif Jameel Poverty Action Lab's Agriculture Program including the Agricultural Technology Adoption Initiative (ATAI), funded by the Bill and Melinda Gates Foundation (BMGF) and the UK Department for International Development, (DFID) in collaboration with the Center of Evaluation for Global Action at UC Berkeley
- Overseeing subawards from ATAI to researchers at universities and research centers globally as well as monitoring progress and reporting.
- Managing relationships with donors, including biweekly calls with program officers, developing new proposals, and annual reports, resulting in new awards of over $8 million to dates
- Presented on research in agriculture at forums in the United Arab Emirates, the United States, India, Morocco, and Sierra Leone to government officials, researchers, private sector partners, and non-profit staff
- Developing a variety of materials for disseminating results of agriculture research including a short film about a project on weather index insurance in northern Ghana
- Writing and editing policy briefs and blog posts, including a bulletin on weather index insurance and a post on the Next Billion blog
- Running conferences providing evidence to policymakers about effective interventions in agriculture and hosting opportunities to develop partnerships between researchers, NGOs, and governments
- Organizing, producing materials, and teaching at working shops for CIMMYT in Texcoco, Mexico to train their researchers in randomized evaluations looking at social outcomes including profitability
- Maintaining the various resources associated with the Agriculture Program including the ATAI website and a white paper on barriers to technology adoption in agriculture
- Managing a competitive request for proposal process to fund research projects in Sub-Saharan Africa and South Asia, including organizing board meetings, supporting the award process, and receiving reports on projects

Innovations for Poverty Action *Freetown, Sierra Leone*

Acting Country Director *2011*

- Acted as in-country representative for Innovations for Poverty Action in Sierra Leone
- Met and negotiated projects with a variety of partners including the International Rescue Committee, Fombul Tok, Search for Common Ground, Campaign for Good Governance, UNICEF, the International Growth Centre, IFAD, ChildFund, the Ministry of Finance and Economic Development, and the World Bank
- Managed a staff of 30 people including international project associates, local research assistants, and office staff
- Supported the activities of randomized evaluations and other methods focusing on rice cultivation using NERICA, village-level health clinic quality, community reconciliation, micro-loans for palm oil producers, rice traders in local markets, contract design in the cocoa industry, village-level child protection, and performance of MPs
- Performed the above while maintaining oversight of HR, recruitment, and reporting tasks associated with the position as Research manager at the Abdul Latif Jameel Poverty Action Lab

Abdul Latif Jameel Poverty Action Lab (J-PAL), MIT *Cambridge, Massachusetts, USA*

Research Manager *2010 - 2014*

- Oversaw global recruitment efforts for J-PAL and partner organizations, managing a database of over 100 job opening per year, and receiving applications from over 4,000 global candidates
- Developed and leaded a global review system of applicants to J-PAL's database reviewing more than 1,800 candidates by over 40 staff located around the world and in different organizations
- Supported the development and management of MIS, using Salesforce and Sharepoint
- Introduced new affiliates to J-PAL's services and policies and systematically collected affiliates' regional and sector research interests
- Prepared content and presenting at staff trainings on field research methods in Kenya, India, and the US
- Tracked and maintained over 500 research projects taking place around the world coordinating with professors from top university, managers in central offices, and researchers in the field.
- Researched and wrote general-funding grant proposals and annual reports for major donors contributing several million dollars yearly
- Designed and implemented human resource procedures for staff based at the labs regional offices and for professor's newly affiliated with the lab including orientation to SharePoint

University of California, San Diego *La Jolla, California, USA*

Research Assistant *2010*

- Assisted professors from UC San Diego and UC Berkeley with the organization and operation of experimental research investigating consumer demand of Fair Trade coffee
- Established and managed relationships with coffee shops in the San Diego area where the experiments took place
- Designed materials and survey instruments used in the experiment

Grameen Foundation *Washington, DC, USA*

Quantitative Analysis Intern *2009 - 2010*

- Performed regression analysis looking at covariation between Grameen's Progress Out of Poverty Index and several microfinance indicators
- Examined and cleaned provided data in order to ensure valid results
- Organized and set goals for the team of interns working jointly on the project

PlaNet Finance *Beijing China*

Graduate Student Intern *2009*

- Led and assessed a group of interns producing a book describing the experiences of microfinance loan recipients
- Researched and compiled a list of potential donors to PlaNet Finance
- Designed a draft questionnaire to evaluate interns sent to assist microfinance banks in rural areas
- Evaluated English translation of the articles of association of a new microfinance bank in Ningxia province
- Designed and produced a PowerPoint presentation and other promotional materials for fundraiser raising over 30,000 RMB for projects in Gansu province related to reconstruction after the 2008 earthquake

Teaching experience

University of California, San Diego — *La Jolla, California, USA*

Econometrics Teacher's Assistant — *2010*

- Lead bi-weekly course reviews of material covered in class including econometrics theory and the data analysis program STATA
- Grade homeworks and tests for a class of over 100 students
- Address individual students' questions and concerns in class as well as by email and instant message
- Contribute to weekly meetings with course professor to improve instruction and tackle student concerns

University of California, San Diego — *La Jolla, California, USA*

Statistics Tutor — *2009*

- Led small group tutoring sessions covering the basics of probability theory including several probability distributions and hypothesis testing
- Taught students how to use Excel in questions concerning probability
- Tracked student performance in order to address and highlight specific issues with the instructor

Santa Barbara City College — *Jinan, China*

English Tutor — *2001*

- Highlighted nuanced aspects of conversational English by crafting presentations and class plans
- Expanded students' knowledge of English beyond the classroom utilizing a variety of improvised settings
- Overcame language and cultural obstacles to capably teach students

University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill — *Chapel HIll, North Carolina, USA*

Math Tutor — *2001 - 2004*

- Clarified complex mathematical concepts to students with a wide range of abilities, yielding exceptional academic achievement
- Crafted individualized teaching techniques to address wide ranging gaps in mathematical learning

Mangement Experience

Joe Van Gogh — *Hillsborough, North Carolina, USA*

Retail Manager — *2004 - 2008*

- Designed a company-wide detailed training program to ensure that staff at all levels had the knowledge and skills necessary for outstanding drink preparation and customer service
- Strategically managed a staff of 30 employees utilizing each individual's unique strengths to increase productivity and overall morale reducing staff turnover to 5% per year
- Generated budgets and established fiscal goals resulting in reduced shrink, increased profitability and more efficient allocation of resources leading to 5% increase in company income
- Communicated company objectives and addressed specific employee concerns leading to standardized procedures, improved operations, and increased quality of service
- Rose through the store hierarchy from barista to store manager in 9 months

Other activities

Interagency Council on Evaluation Policy (ICEP) — *Washington, DC, USA*

ICEP Member — *2023 - present*

- Member of the ICEP consultations working group, hosting open discussions on evaluation activities in Federal government

National Association of Welfare Research and Statistics (NAWRS) — *Saint Paul, Minnesota, USA*

NAWRS Program Co-Chair — *2022 - present*

- Program development for NAWRS conferences in 2023 and 2025

National Association of Welfare Research and Statistics (NAWRS) — *Saint Paul, Minnesota, USA*

NAWRS Virtual Committee Member — *2020 - 2022*

- Developed presentation ideas and invited speakers to online presentations about a variety of human services topics

Global Innovation Fund — *London, UK*

Proposal Reviewer — *2015*

- Reviewed proposals for agriculture development studies in the developing world

Other honors

Minnesota Department of Management and Budget — *Saint Paul, Minnesota, USA*

Emerging Leaders Institute — *2019*

- Leadership development program designed to prepare future leaders in Minnesota state government

US Office of Personnel Management — *Washington, DC, USA*

Presidential Management Fellows Finalist — *2010*

- Flagship leadership development program for US federal government positions

Selected Presentations

Association for Public Policy Analysis & Management — *National Harbor, Maryland*

2024 APPAM Fall Research Conference — *2024*

- Effects of Remote Designation on Candidate Interest and Selection in the Federal Workforce
- Social Insurance in Farming and Well-Being (Chair)

National Association of Welfare Research and Statistics (NAWRS) — *Salt Lake City, Utah*

NAWRS 2023 Workshop — *2023*

- Cultivating An Evidence-Driven Leadership Practice In TANF And Related Programs (Moderator)
- Using Learn, Innovate, Improve (Li2) To Support Evidence-Driven Change: Lessons From The Redesign of the Iowa Family Development and Self-Sufficiency (FaDSS) Home Visiting Program (Moderator)
- Collecting and Using Data on Employment Outcomes to Improve TANF Employment Programs (Panelist)
- Minnesota Emergency SNAP Data Story

U.S. Department of Health and Human Services, Administration for Children and Families, Office of Family Assistance — *Webinar*

OFA Webinar — *2023*

- Using Program Success Metrics and Organizational Change Principles to Implement Responsive and Modernized TANF Programs

US General Services Administration — *Webinar*

PMA Learning Agenda Workforce Symposium — *2023*

- Maximizing Effective Hybrid Work Environments

U.S. Department of Health and Human Services, Administration for Children and Families, Office of Family Assistance — *Webinar*

OFA Webinar — *2022*

- Centering Racial Equity in TANF Data Use

Administration for Children and Families — *Webinar*

Research and Evaluation Conference on Self-Sufficiency 2022 — *2022*

- TANF Data Collaborative: How States are Building Data Analytics Capacity and Experiences of Families on TANF
- Experiences and Perspectives of TANF-Eligible Individuals and TANF Recipients

Twin Cities Research Group (TCRG) — *Saint Paul, Minnesota*

TCRG Webinar — *2022*

- Employment and Family Cash Assistance in Minnesota

University of Minnesota — *Minneapolis, Minnesota*

Data, Rigor, and Reproducibility in Light of Diversity, Equity, and Inclusion — *2021*

- Centering racial equity across the data life cycle

American Public Human Services Association and the National Association of Welfare Research Statistics — *Milwaukee, Wisconsin*

Economic Mobility and Well-Being Conference — *2021*

- TANF Data Collaborative: How States are Building Data Analytics Capacity

Twin Cities Research Group (TCRG) — *Saint Paul, MN, USA*

TCRG Webinar — *2020*

- Variance of MFIP Grants in Minnesota

National Association of Welfare Research and Statistics (NAWRS) — *New Orleans, Louisiana, USA*

NAWRS 2019 Workshop — *2019*

- Variance of MFIP Grants in Minnesota

Minnesota Financial Worker & Case Aide Association — *Minneapolis Minnesota*

MFWCAA 2018 Conference: Passport To Excellence — *2018*

- Pressures and Tensions of Living on a Low Income

Minnesota Department of Human Services and Minnesota Department of Employment and Economic Development — *Rochester, MN, USA*

Joint Counselor Training — *2017*

- Pressures and Tensions of Living on a Low-Income

Global Development Network (GDN) — *Casablanca, Morocco*

Agriculture for Sustainable Growth: Challenges and Opportunites for a New 'Green Revolution' — *2015*

- Stimulating Smallholder Technology Adoption: Lessons from Tandomized Trials in Credit and Insurance

International Initiative for Impact Evaluation (3ie) — *New Delhi, India*

Delhi Seminar — *2015*

- Emerging Policy Lessons in Agriculture

Massachusetts Institute of Technology — *Cambridge, MA, USA*

OCP Executive Education — *2015*

- Emerging Policy Lessons in Agriculture

US Department of Agriculture — *Des Moines, Iowa, USA*
World Food Prize Preconference — *2015*

- Emerging Policy Lessons in Agriculture

OCP Policy Center — *Marrakesh, Morocco*
Atlantic Dialogues — *2014*

- Emerging Policy Lessons in Agriculture

Sierra Leone Ministry of Agriculture, Forestry and Food Security — *Freetown, Sierra Leone*
Seminar on Randomized Evaluations in Agriculture — *2014*

- Emerging Policy Lessons in Agriculture

Abdul Latif Jameel Povery Action and Innovations for Poverty Action — *Doha, Qatar*
Evaluating Social Programs — *2013*

- Emerging Policy Lessons in Agriculture

Publications

1. *Digging For Answers: Examining the Effects of Rainfall Index Insurance for Farmers in Ghana*. (2015). Abdul Latif Jameel Poverty Action Lab, Center for Effective Global Action,; Innovations for Poverty Action. https://www.youtube.com/watch?v=DWWx2h-b3v4
2. Jaques-Leslie, B. (2016). Making it Rain: The forecast on weather index insurance. In *NextBillion*. https://nextbillion.net/making-it-rain-the-forecast-on-weather-index-insurance/
3. Jaques-Leslie, B. P. (2017). *Self-Support Index Methodology Update* (p. 72). Minnesota Department of Human Services. https://edocs.dhs.state.mn.us/lfserver/Public/DHS-6724A-ENG
4. Jaques-Leslie, B. (2019). *Income variability of families on cash assistance in Minnesota* (No. 1; p. 4). Minnesota Department of Human Services. https://edocs.dhs.state.mn.us/lfserver/Public/DHS-3927A-ENG
5. Jaques-Leslie, B. (2020). *Using master leasing to support Olmsted County families* (No. 1; p. 3). Minnesota Department of Human Services. https://edocs.dhs.state.mn.us/lfserver/Public/DHS-7346A-ENG
6. Jaques-Leslie, B. P. (2020). *Minnesota Family Investment Program Performance Measures by Racial/Ethnic or Immigrant Group and by County or Tribal Provider* (p. 53). Minnesota Department of Human Services. https://edocs.dhs.state.mn.us/lfserver/Public/DHS-4214AF-ENG
7. Jaques-Leslie, B. P. (2020). *Self-Support Index: Recommended Changes to the Model* (p. 32). Minnesota Department of Human Services. https://edocs.dhs.state.mn.us/lfserver/Public/DHS-7355A-ENG
8. Jaques-Leslie, B. P. (2020). *Self-Support Index Future Work* (p. 5). Minnesota Department of Human Services. https://edocs.dhs.state.mn.us/lfserver/Public/DHS-7355B-ENG
9. Jaques-Leslie, B. P. (2020). *Minnesota Family Investment Program 2020 Annualized Self-Support Index* (p. 12). Minnesota Department of Human Services. https://edocs.dhs.state.mn.us/lfserver/Public/DHS-4651G-ENG
10. Jaques-Leslie, B. (2021). *Minnesota Family Investment Program Management Indicators Report*. Minnesota Department of Human Services. https://edocs.dhs.state.mn.us/lfserver/Public/DHS-4042AF-ENG
11. Jaques-Leslie, B. (2025). *The effects of remote designation on applications and selections to federal government jobs*. U.S. Office of Personnel Management. https://www.opm.gov/about-us/reports-publications/agency-reports/brief-on-the-effect-of-the-remote-work-designation-on-hiring/
12. Jaques-Leslie, B., & Vonderharr, T. (2022). *Collaborative evaluation by White Earth Nation and the Minnesota Department of Human Services* (No. 2; p. 11). Minnesota Department of Human Services; White Earth Nation. https://edocs.dhs.state.mn.us/lfserver/Public/DHS-7346B-ENG
13. NIkolla, D., & Jaques-Leslie, B. (2019). *The effect of child support disregard on MFIP grant* (No. 2; p. 4). Minnesota Department of Human Services. https://edocs.dhs.state.mn.us/lfserver/Public/DHS-3927B-ENG
14. Schickele, A. (2016). *Make it Rain* (B. Jaques-Leslie, Ed.; p. 12). Abdul Latif Jameel Poverty Action Lab, Center for Effective Global Action,; Agricultural Technology Adoption Initiative. https://www.povertyactionlab.org/sites/default/files/publication/make-it-rain.pdf

Additional information

- **Computer Skills**: R, Github, AzureDevops, SQL, STATA, MS Office, Salesforce, SharePoint, ArcGIS (limited) Python (limited), Julia (limited)
- **Volunteer Activities**: Minneapolis Parks and Recreation, Saint Paul United Church of Christ, Amnesty International, First Church Somerville, MIT SHASS, People's Self-Help Housing, Lutheran Family Services, International Rescue Committee
- **Leadership**: Judge, Southeast Regional Barista Competition
- **International Experience**: Kenya, Morocco, Sierra Leone, China, India, South Korea, Thailand, Vietnam, Egypt, United Arab Emirates, Qatar, Brazil, Mexico, Canada, France, Italy, the Netherlands, Spain, Turkey, and UK